nation. Yitzhak Navon, a Sephardic Jew who spoke eloquent Arabic, helped to cement the peace treaty with Egypt on his historic 1980 visit to Cairo. Others were less distinguished: Moshe Katsav, who held the post from 2000 to 2007, is best known for resigning amidst rape allegations and then being sentenced to prison.

None had the stature of the nonagenarian Shimon Peres, a leading figure on the Israeli political scene for nearly half a century and a darling of the international community. President Obama awarded him the Medal of Freedom in 2012, calling him "the essence of Israel itself, an indomitable spirit that will not be denied." His ninetieth birthday celebration the following year drew an A-list crowd, from Bill Clinton and Mikhail Gorbachev to Barbra Streisand and Robert DeNiro. "Shimon, you are the world's social Einstein. You have tried to put together a unified theory of meaning," Clinton told him.

In some ways, the reputation was undeserved. As the defense minister in 1975, Peres helped to authorize one of the earliest Israeli settlements, Ofra. He was an advocate for the settler movement, describing it in 1976 as the "roots and eyes of Israel."[4] He genuinely moved to the left in his later years, but his main goal was always political survival. Even during his time as president—which would clearly be his final job, his last chance to leave a mark—he spent five-plus years offering political cover to Netanyahu.

In a December 2012 interview with *Der Spiegel*, he insisted that the hawkish prime minister would surprise his critics. "Netanyahu agreed to a two-state solution," Peres said, when asked about the four-year period after Netanyahu took office, during which he broke off talks with the Palestinians. "Those four years will not be repeated… I am sure Netanyahu doesn't want a binational state."[5] It was only in late 2015, more than a year after his retirement, that Peres finally spoke the truth. Netanyahu's overtures, he admitted to the Associated Press, had never "escaped the domain of talking."[6] An obvious conclusion for anyone familiar with Netanyahu's history—but Peres denied it until his voice no longer carried any official weight.

Nobody harbored any such illusions about Reuven Rivlin, one of the two candidates who led the spring 2014 race to replace Peres. He was, and is, a staunch opponent of the two-state solution, and a supporter of continued settlement in the occupied territories. His candidacy also provoked unease within the Reform community, the dominant Jewish sect in the United